

The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

MONDAY, OCTOBER 6, 2025 • \$4

SSA looks to limit disability benefits

Plan would not consider age in deciding whether someone is able to work

BY MYREL KORNFIELD
AND LISA REIN

The Trump administration is preparing a plan that would make it harder for older Americans to qualify for Social Security disability payments, part of an overhaul of the federal safety net for poor, older and disabled people that could result in hundreds of thousands of people losing benefits, according to people familiar with the plans.

The Social Security Administration evaluates disability claims by considering age, work experience and education to determine if a person can adjust to other types of work. Older applicants, typically over 50, have a better chance of qualifying because age is treated as a limitation in adapting to many jobs.

But now officials are considering eliminating age as a factor entirely or raising the threshold to age 60, according to three people familiar with the plans who spoke on the condition of anonymity to share private discussions. They also plan to modernize labor market data used to judge whether claimants can work, replacing an outdated jobs database that includes obsolete occupations such as nut sorters and telephone quotation clerks, following a Washington Post investigation in 2022.

It is unclear exactly how many Americans could lose access to disability benefits under the proposed rule changes.

Jack Smalligan, a senior policy
SEE **DISABILITY** ON A9

Farm lobby won a MAHA report soft on pesticides

BY AMUDALAT AJASA
AND RACHEL ROUBEIN

Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has a reputation for bashing powerful corporate interests in his quest to “Make America Healthy Again.” But one industry has eked out a win under Kennedy’s MAHA agenda: Big Agriculture.

In May, the Trump administration’s MAHA commission released a report raising questions about the health effects of two commonly used pesticides, glyphosate and atrazine. The report’s rhetoric frustrated powerful agriculture groups such as CropLife America and the American Soybean Association, prompting them to launch a concerted lobbying blitz to promote the chemicals farmers rely on to produce large crops, according to interviews with industry officials.

Major trade groups scrambled to meet with White House officials. They urged the commission in a coordinated social media campaign to take a “fact-based approach,” and sent letters to key federal departments. A top industry group helped coordinate a visit of Trump officials to a Maryland farm to see farming techniques in action. And in June, an industry lobbyist was appointed to a key position at the Environmental Protection Agency.

SEE **PESTICIDES** ON A6

Fumble recovery toward ecstasy



ERIC THAYER/AP

Quan Martin (20) forced a fumble in the second quarter Sunday, a turnover that turned the tide in Washington’s 27-10 victory over the Los Angeles Chargers in Inglewood, California. At the time, the Chargers were ahead 10-0 and driving for another score, but Jayden Daniels and the Commanders scored the final 27 points. **Story, C1**

Core Trump policies await final verdicts from high court

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

The Supreme Court and President Donald Trump are headed for a reckoning.

After months of terse emergency rulings that largely avoided major confrontations with the new administration, the justices will open their new term Monday faced with the need to render full, final verdicts on policies at the core of Trump’s presidency.

“It really is going to be a showdown,” said Jennifer Nou, a law professor at the University of Chicago. “So many of the president’s big-ticket constitutional issues and policy initiatives are quickly coming up before the court. All of this is coming to a head.”

Already on the docket is a case challenging the legality of most of the tariffs at the heart of Trump’s economic policy and another dealing with his aggressive push to exert greater control over independent agencies.

Though it is an emergency appeal, the justices are treating a case over whether Trump can fire Federal Reserve governor Lisa Cook like one on the regular docket. It will determine the independence of the central bank and could have major implications for the U.S. economy, businesses and consumers.

The justices could also be called upon in the coming months to issue up-or-down decisions on Trump’s bid to end
SEE **SUPREME COURT** ON A7

Some D.C. police eagerly help feds probe crime stats

BY JENNY GATHRIGHT
AND OLIVIA GEORGE

D.C. police officers are feeding information to the Justice Department as it probes accusations of manipulated crime data, according to the D.C. Police Union and five other people familiar with the situation who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss an investigation in progress. The voluntary cooperation of about three dozen from the police force, according to three of the people, reflects long-standing frustrations about how violent crime is categorized by supervisors — and surfaces as public safety in D.C. continues to capture the president’s attention.

Some rank-and-file officers and

detectives have complained for months — in some cases, years — that managers were recording serious crimes as more minor ones to make their police districts appear safer or avoid the ire of top department brass. Some kept lists, documenting cases where they believed a higher-up improperly classified a crime as a lesser offense. One such tally, obtained by The Washington Post, lists more than 150 instances since March of 2024 in which staff in a Southeast Washington police district believed offenses were, at least initially, inappropriately classified.

At the heart of the Justice Department probe, and another by a House committee, is whether
SEE **CRIME** ON A2

Battles escalate over use of Guard

STATES PLEDGE TO FIGHT IN COURT

Trump seeks to send Calif. troops to Portland

BY HOLLY BAILEY,
PRAVEENA SOMASUNDARAM
AND JOSEPH MENN

State officials pledged Sunday to fight the Trump administration in court over its efforts to send troops into Democratic-led cities, after a weekend of heated confrontations between protesters and federal agents in Chicago and Portland led to multiple arrests.

California Gov. Gavin Newsom (D) said his state would sue over President Donald Trump’s plan to deploy hundreds of California National Guard troops to Portland, after a judge Saturday temporarily blocked the administration from sending Oregon’s National Guard into that city. The Pentagon confirmed Sunday that Trump ordered about 200 National Guard members to be reassigned from California.

“This is a breathtaking abuse of the law and power,” Newsom said in a statement. “The Trump Administration is unapologetically attacking the rule of law itself and putting into action their dangerous words — ignoring court orders and treating judges, even those appointed by the President himself, as political opponents.”

Oregon Attorney General Dan Rayfield (D) said the state would expand its legal effort to include fighting deployments from out of state, accusing the president of being “hell-bent” on using the military “absent the facts or authority to do so.”

“It is up to us and the courts to hold him accountable,” Rayfield said on X.

The Trump administration, which has said troops are needed to protect Immigration and Customs Enforcement facilities and agents conducting operations, has appealed the restraining order in Portland, where U.S. District Judge Karin J. Immergut
SEE **PROTESTS** ON A8

Trauma and suicides spike among Israeli troops amid Gaza war

Military scrambles to address an issue once regarded as taboo

BY SHIRA RUBIN,
HEIDI LEVINE
AND LIOR SOROKA

SITRIA, ISRAEL — Hours after Hamas assailants streamed from Gaza into Israel two years ago, Amir Lorch jumped in his car and sped to the site of the massacre, helping to gather the shattered bodies of his fellow Israelis.

He then deployed in late October 2023 as a reservist with the Israeli army to the central Gaza Strip and witnessed, he said, “what people are capable of in times of revenge, when no one sees you and the thing that comes out is something dark.”

It was when Lorch was discharged in December of that year and reclaimed his job as the head of artificial intelligence at a Tel Aviv start-up that the lows began, he recalled. Images of charred, mangled bodies stalked



HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Amir Lorch, 32, left, a former reservist suffering from PTSD, pets a horse at an Israeli farm last month.

IN THE NEWS

Returned to Afghanistan More than 1 million refugees in Pakistan, many awaiting resettlement in the United States, have been pressured to leave or been deported. A10

Super Bowl halftime show On “Saturday Night Live,” Bad Bunny mocked conservative critics of his selection as headliner. A5

THE NATION Where a teenager fell to his death in Utah, a journal helps keep his memory alive. A2
California’s mandate that high schools offer an ethnic studies course has stalled. A3

THE WORLD In Russia, AI is being used to give deceased soldiers a haunting kind of second life. A11
An assault by Russia on Ukraine’s energy infrastructure left at least five people dead. A11

THE ECONOMY Colorado regulators have approved a dramatic price cap on one of the nation’s best-selling drugs. A16

STYLE Shakespearean imagery features prominently on Taylor Swift’s new album. These scholars approve. B1

SPORTS The Spirit scored an accidental goal late in stoppage time to beat the Wave, 2-1, at Audi Field. C10

THE REGION The Prince George’s County Council is set to vote on pared-down legislation to aid laid-off federal workers. C11

A lawsuit argues that the U.S. Parole Commission cannot jail people because it no longer legally exists after congressional inaction. C11

HEALTH & SCIENCE The mountain lion is perhaps the last big piece of the “rewilding” puzzle east of the Mississippi. D1

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